I was taken aback, but not unnerved, and replied, ‘These are authorized pattern brogue shoes, Sir.’

‘But don’t you know that we are a mountain brigade?’

‘Yes sir, I do,’ I said, looking at the big boots that he was wearing. I got the message. Thereafter, not only did I procure the boots but also the ordnance pattern socks that our soldiers wore!

We had an important brigade-level exercise in a high-altitude area in Sikkim. During the exercise we were rehearsing our operational role. At a critical juncture, the brigade commander’s wireless operator collapsed and there was no one to carry the radio set. It was raining and freezing cold. I remained cool and just picked up the set and strapped it on my shoulders. I told the COs I was manning the radio set, and that it would help if they responded when I called. The command and control was more effective this way. The exercise went off well, and Brigadier Vadehra was more than happy. Thereafter, I couldn’t do any wrong. After a few months, we were permitted to bring our families to the station. So I asked Rohini and the children to join me. We lived in a bamboo-walled structure with a roof made of CGI (corrugated galvanized iron) sheets. Wherever we have lived in the last four decades since our marriage, Rohini has made the house into a home. One night the whole thing was shaking and we felt as if there was an earthquake, only to be told that there was a herd of elephants around and that we should switch on our lights and not venture outside. We were also told that our Brigade HQ was located in the middle of an elephant trail, so they had the right of way.

Once we narrowly escaped being trampled by a rogue elephant. This incident took place when we were travelling in a jeep to Siliguri. Seeing many vehicles crowded at a point, the driver slowed down. I presumed that there had been an accident and told the driver to press on. As he did so, the jeep came to a halt after about a hundred yards. As the driver got down and lifted the bonnet, we noticed a wild elephant advancing towards us from the forest. We just froze, me on the front left seat and Rohini, the kids and a maid at the back. The elephant had come so close that we could smell his body odour. Suddenly the driver began to chant ‘Jai Ganesh, Jai